

ANI

within the AAP Punjab unit for things to unravel on their own by the time the election rolls in.

DAMAGE CONTROL

Ask about AAP's latest troubles and Sanjay Singh will tell you that the BJP has perfected the "politics of defections", using the ED and CBI as instruments to poach MPs who "benefited from AAP's ticket and then sold us out". "Our people everywhere are being persecuted by the BJP to [force them to] quit," Singh says. He cites the examples of party MLAs Mehraj Malik in J&K and Chaitar Vasava in Gujarat, who were jailed on "trumped-up charges". On the Rajya Sabha MP defections, Singh says AAP will move the Supreme Court to seek their disqualification.

Meanwhile, AAP chief Kejriwal does not seem to have even a day to spare on internal damage control. "The BJP wants this episode (the exit of the seven MPs) to take over the narrative, but we will not allow that. This has no bearing on the larger fight," says a senior AAP functionary. The excise case in the Delhi HC has been top of the agenda for Kejriwal and AAP, and visibly so. The AAP chief has announced that he will abstain from all future hearings before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, who is hearing a CBI challenge to a lower court's ruling discharging him, close aide Manish Sisodia and others.

Kejriwal had written directly to the judge after a court rejected his petition for Justice Sharma's recusal from the case. In his plaint, he had cited her "public association with the RSS's legal front" and the fact that her children are on the panel of the central government counsel under solicitor general Tushar Mehta, who is appearing on behalf of the CBI in the excise policy case. Sisodia has also announced he would abstain, citing the same reasons and saying he "did not expect to get justice" in judge Sharma's court. The judicial boycott also gives AAP workers something to rally around—a persecution narrative far simpler than any anti-defection petition. The AAP top leadership now says "there is no path left except for *satyagraha*". Kejriwal even led a march of AAP workers to Rajghat in the capital, where he and others paid floral tributes at Gandhiji's samadhi.

AAP finds itself in a piquant situation today, another victim of the BJP's 'thousand cuts' strategy. Corruption allegations, defections, the defeat in Delhi, they have all but erased memories of the brief high after Kejriwal's discharge in the excise case in February. Yet the situation is not completely lost. AAP's immediate challenge is to regain control of the narrative. The leadership will need to reassure the cadre in times when the words 'organisational discipline' will ring hollow. It will also have to refocus attention on governance outcomes rather than the internal churn. The next few months will test the mettle of Kejriwal and Co. like no other period before. AAP will have to minimise the damage and rebuild momentum ahead of the 2027 election or risk being pushed to the margins for ever. ■

WHAT NEXT FOR AAM AADMI PARTY?

The party must find new ways to stay relevant

- **AAP strategy now hinges on limiting any possible defections from its Punjab unit, fortifying CM Bhagwant Mann and making 2027 a straight contest against BJP's "poaching" politics**
- **Kejriwal is unlikely to soften his persecution-and-*satyagraha* narrative, leveraging the legal fights to re-energise his cadre while deflecting attention from internal housekeeping issues**
- **Gains in the Gujarat local body polls give AAP a small window for expansion, makes it look more nationally relevant despite setbacks in Delhi**
- **AAP leadership will likely become more centralised, with old loyalty and ideological discipline underscoring future organisational decisions**
- **AAP must refocus attention on governance outcomes rather than the internal churn**
- **Litmus test will be Punjab in '27—will AAP persevere, become a politically durable machine or sink into the margins?**